

The most powerful skill we're never taught is deciding what to ignore.

Someone who can concentrate on what truly matters will achieve more than someone who can't.

When everything seems equally important, we waste precious time on things that don't advance us toward our goals. You can spend your energy on what's important or what's not – but trying to do both only undermines only what's important.

Learning what to ignore is the key to focusing on what matters. This sounds simpler than it is.

Consider Albert Einstein. Many believe his genius lay in his mathematical ability. But while he was certainly talented, those who knew him considered his mathematical skills relatively ordinary.

So how did someone with average mathematical ability become one of history's greatest scientists?

His true gift was different – and often overlooked.

Einstein had an extraordinary ability to cut through complexity and focus on what was essential. When others got lost in complicated details, he could zero in on what really mattered by ignoring the rest.

As physicist John Wheeler noted in his memoir about Einstein, his genius wasn't in understanding more complex things than others – it was in recognizing the fundamental importance of simplicity.